1.3 Conquering the Aztec and Inca

The Aztec and Inca were more curious than worried when Spanish soldiers first arrived on horseback. Little did they know that Spanish invaders would enlist allies and topple both empires.

MAIN IDEA A variety of factors helped Spanish soldiers and adventurers conquer the Aztec and Inca empires in the 16th century.

INVADING MEXICO

For several decades, the Spanish had little interference from other Europeans in exploring and colonizing the Americas. **Conquistadors** (kon-KEE-stuh-dohrz), or Spanish soldiers and adventurers, conquered the native tribes of many Caribbean islands, claiming the lands for Spain. They then moved through present-day Mexico and Central America. By 1543, Spanish settlements extended south to Chile, north to present-day Florida, and west to California.

Hernán Cortés was one of the most successful conquistadors. In 1519, he launched an expedition into the vast Aztec Empire in Mexico. As Cortés and his small Spanish force moved toward the Aztec capital of Tenochtitlán (tay-nohch-teet-LAHN), they recruited allies from some Native American tribes that were dissatisfied with Aztec rule. They seized the Aztec emperor **Moctezuma** (mahk-tuh-ZOO-muh), who believed the light-skinned, bearded Spaniards signaled the return of the Aztec god Quetzalcoatl (kwet-sul-kuh-WAH-tuhl). Some historians think this is one reason Cortés was able to capture Moctezuma.



The Museum of Fine Arts, Houston

The Inca were spectacular artisans. This figure, fashioned from silver, copper, shell, and polished stone, dates from between 1200 and 1532. The Spanish melted most such figures to reuse the precious metals.

Controlling Tenochtitlán proved more difficult. When the Spanish outlawed human sacrifice—an important part of Aztec religion—and demanded more gold, the Aztec rebelled. They forced the Spanish and their allies to retreat, killing many in the process. After Cortés regrouped, he returned in May 1521 with more Spanish troops and allies and laid siege to Tenochtitlán.

The Aztec fought bravely, even though they were already weakened by a deadly outbreak of a disease the Spanish carried, called **smallpox**. In the end, though, the Spanish destroyed the city of Tenochtitlán. Over time, the Spanish colonizers spread their culture throughout Mexico. In fact, the Spanish built Mexico City on the ruins of Tenochtitlán.

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CRITICAL VIEWING In the late 1600s, an unknown artist depicted the conquest of Tenochtitlán. Based on details you notice in the painting, what advantages did the Spanish and the Aztec each have as they faced each other in battle?



PIZARRO'S QUEST FOR GOLD

When the Spanish arrived in the Americas, the Inca already controlled a powerful empire stretching along the Andes Mountains in South America. Stories of Inca gold and silver interested the Spanish conquistador **Francisco Pizarro**. So in the 1530s, with around 180 men and a small number of horses, Pizarro set out from Panama to conquer the Inca.

In 1532, the Inca emperor **Atahualpa** invited Pizarro and his men to a meeting in the northern part of present-day Peru. At the meeting, Atahualpa and Pizarro exchanged gifts to show goodwill toward each other. Atahualpa was confident that the presence of his 6,000 warriors would discourage Pizarro from attacking. But the emperor was wrong.

Pizarro's men opened fire on the mostly unarmed Inca and took Atahualpa prisoner. Atahualpa offered Pizarro gold and silver, which Pizarro took. Then he had Atahualpa killed. By 1537, the Spanish had crushed Inca opposition.

Several factors helped the Spanish conquer the Aztec and the Inca. Smallpox and other European diseases killed or weakened many Aztec, Inca, and Native Americans. The Spanish were masterful at forming alliances with Native American groups, especially with tribes opposing the Aztec. Aztec and Inca weapons were no match for the guns and swift horses of the Spanish. Finally, the Spanish used violence and forced labor to control Native American populations and put down revolts.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What was the goal of the Spanish conquistadors?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What factors helped the Spanish defeat the Aztec and Inca?
3. **DRAW CONCLUSIONS** What might have led Aztec and Inca leaders to underestimate the Spanish invaders?

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